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DEPARTMENT OF WILDLIFE CONSERVATION (DWC) SRI LANKA - RULES & PERMITS

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1. YALA NATIONAL PARK (BLOCK 1 & 2)

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Morning slot: 6:00 AM - 10:00 AM. Afternoon slot: 2:30 PM - 6:00 PM.

- **Entry Permits:** Must be purchased at the Palatupana entrance gate or online via the official DWC portal.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 250) + Tracker/Guide Fee.

- **Safari Vehicle Rules:**

- * Maximum speed limit inside the park is 25 km/h.
- * Off-road driving is strictly prohibited and results in immediate license cancellation for the driver.
- * Visitors must remain inside the safari jeep at all times except at designated rest sites (e.g., Manik Ganga rest area).
- * Drones are strictly forbidden without prior written approval from DWC and the Civil Aviation Authority.

- **Overnight Camping:**

- * Permitted only at designated DWC campsite locations (e.g., Yala Block 1 campsites).
- * Campers must bring all waste back out (Leave No Trace).
- * Open campfires are restricted to designated fire pits only.

2. HORTON PLAINS NATIONAL PARK

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 4:00 PM. Visitors must exit by 6:00 PM.

- **Single-Use Plastic Ban:** Polythene bags, plastic food wrappers, plastic water bottles, and Styrofoam containers are strictly prohibited at the entry gate. Baggage checks are mandatory.

- **Trail Regulations:**

- * Visitors must stay on the designated World's End / Baker's Falls loop trail (9 km).
- * Straying from marked paths into delicate cloud forest ecosystems is an offense under the Fauna and Flora Protection Ordinance.
- * Feeding wild animals (especially Sambar deer) is strictly illegal and attracts heavy fines.

3. WILPATTU NATIONAL PARK

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Ticket counter opens at 6:00 AM.

- **Entry Permits:** Issued at Hunuwilgama (Main Entrance) and Eluwankulama gates, or online via DWC portal.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Service Charge (~USD 10/vehicle) + Vehicle Fee (LKR 300) + Mandatory Tracker Fee.

- **Villu Ecosystem Protection:**

* Driving off designated gravel tracks or into delicate "Villu" (natural rainwater basin) lake margins is strictly illegal.

- * Maximum vehicle speed limit is 25 km/h.

- **Wildlife & Camping Rules:**

* Remaining in safari vehicles is mandatory except at designated stretches (e.g., Kudiramalai Point).

* DWC bungalow occupants must ensure all food waste is securely sealed to avoid attracting sloth bears and jackals.

4. UDAWALAWE NATIONAL PARK & ELEPHANT TRANSIT HOME

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Ticket counter closes at 4:00 PM.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 300) + Service Charge.

- **Wildlife Proximity Rules:**

* Safari jeeps must maintain a minimum distance of 20 meters from wild elephant herds.

* Feeding, baiting, or calling wild elephants inside the park is a severe criminal offense under the Fauna & Flora Protection Ordinance.

- **Elephant Transit Home (ETH) Directives:**

* Milk feeding public viewing hours: 9:00 AM, 12:00 PM, 3:00 PM, and 6:00 PM.

* Visitors must observe orphaned calves exclusively from designated viewing platforms. Direct physical contact with elephants is strictly forbidden.

- **Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:**

* Park Access: Safari inside the national park is strictly via authorized 4x4 safari jeeps (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

* Vehicle Distance: Jeeps must maintain a minimum distance of 20 meters from wild elephant herds and solitary bulls.

5. MINNERIYA & KAUDULLA NATIONAL PARKS ("THE GATHERING")

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Best safari time: 3:00 PM - 6:00 PM.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 300) + Service Charge.

- **Wildlife Viewing Directives:**

* During the dry season (August-October), safari jeeps must maintain a 30-meter perimeter from elephant herds around the reservoir bed.

* Encircling, speeding, or revving engines near juvenile elephants is prohibited and will result in a park ban.

- * Off-road driving into wetland mudflats is strictly prohibited.

- Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:

- * Access is strictly via authorized 4x4 safari jeeps fitted with high ground clearance (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

- * Speed Limit: Maximum 25 km/h on park tracks; jeeps must slow down to under 10 km/h when approaching elephant herds.

- * Vehicle Distance: Jeeps must maintain a minimum distance of 30 meters from elephant herds on the dry reservoir bed

6. PIGEON ISLAND NATIONAL PARK (TRINCOMALEE)

- Operating Hours: 8:00 AM to 5:00 PM daily (Weather permitting).

- Permit Requirements: Boat and entry permits must be obtained at the DWC office on Nilaveli Beach.

- Marine Protection Rules:

- * Touching, stepping on, or collecting coral (dead or alive) and sea shells is illegal under marine protection laws.

- * Visitors must wear life jackets. Fins that may damage sensitive coral structures are restricted in shallow reef zones.

- * Feeding or disturbing marine life (specifically Blacktip reef sharks and Sea turtles) is strictly forbidden.

- Water Transport & Boat Rules:

- * Access is strictly via authorized motorized boats from Nilaveli Beach.

- * Boats must maintain low speeds near the reef zone and drop anchor only in designated sandy anchoring areas (never on corals).

- * Passengers must wear certified life jackets during the entire boat transit.

7. BUNDALA NATIONAL PARK (RAMSAR WETLAND)

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Best bird watching times: 6:00 AM - 9:00 AM and 3:30 PM - 6:00 PM.

- **Entry Permits:** Issued at the Main Gate visitors' center near Weligatta, or via DWC online portal.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 250) + Tracker Fee.

- **Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:**

* Access inside the wetland reserve is strictly via authorized 4x4 safari jeeps (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

* Speed Limit: Maximum 20 km/h around lagoon circuit tracks to prevent dust clouds that disturb nesting birds.

* Restricted Zones: Driving off-road into wetland mudflats, salt pans, or dune edges is strictly prohibited to protect bird habitats.

- **Wetland Protection Rules:**

* Safari jeeps must stick to marked gravel tracks around the lagoons.

* Disembarking from vehicles is allowed only at designated coastal vantage points (e.g., Bundala beach / Saltern area).

* Distributing bird call playback audio or using high-intensity spotlights near nesting migratory birds is strictly forbidden.

8. WASGAMUWA NATIONAL PARK

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily. Ticket counter opens at 6:00 AM.

- **Entry Permits:** Issued at the Handungamuwa main entrance gate or online via DWC portal.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 300) + Service Charge.

- **Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:**

* Access is strictly limited to authorized 4x4 safari jeeps with high ground clearance (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

- * Speed Limit: Maximum 25 km/h on all inner forest tracks.

- * Elephant Safety Distance: Jeeps must maintain a minimum distance of 20 meters from wild elephant herds at all times.

- * Driver Conduct: Revving engines, blocking river crossing paths, or pursuing herds along Mahaweli riverbank trails is strictly forbidden.

- Wildlife & Elephant Safety Directives:

- * Off-road driving into Mahaweli and Amban River catchment areas is illegal and causes severe riverbank erosion.

- * Camping is allowed only at designated DWC river-side campsites (e.g., Mahaweli campsite) with mandatory waste carry-out policies.

9. KUMANA NATIONAL PARK (YALA EAST)

- Operating Hours: 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily.

- Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists): Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 250) + Tracker Fee.

- Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:

- * Access is strictly via authorized 4x4 safari jeeps operating via the Okanda entrance gate (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

- * Speed Limit: Maximum 20 km/h near the "Kumana Villu" feeding grounds to avoid acoustic disruption to waterfowl.

- * Transit Rules: Jeeps must remain on demarcated gravel tracks and turn off engines at watchtower viewing stops.

- Bird Sanctuary Protocols:

- * Photography inside the core "Kumana Villu" mangrove nesting area must be done silently without disturbing breeding colonies.

- * Drones are strictly forbidden anywhere in the park without specialized permits from DWC and Ministry of Defence.

- * Visitors on foot are restricted solely to designated watchtowers and the Okanda entrance shrine area.

10. MADURU OYA NATIONAL PARK

- **Operating Hours:** 6:00 AM to 6:00 PM daily.

- **Ticket Rates (Foreign Tourists):** Adult USD 25 + Taxes + Vehicle Entrance Fee (~LKR 250) + Tracker Fee.

- **Safari Vehicle & Transport Rules:**

* Access inside the park is strictly via authorized 4x4 safari jeeps (maximum 9 passengers per jeep).

* Speed Limit: Vehicles must maintain a strict maximum speed limit of 25 km/h on all tracks to prevent wildlife collisions.

* Reservoir Access: Jeeps must stay on assigned tracks around the Maduru Oya reservoir margins; driving into submerged vegetation or mudflats is strictly prohibited.

- **Cultural & Wildlife Protection Directives:**

* Visitors must respect sacred and ancient ruin sites within the park boundary (e.g., Ancient Sluice Gate / Bisokotuwa).

* Baiting, feeding, or harassing sloth bears and Asian elephants is an offense punishable by heavy fines or arrest under the Fauna and Flora Protection Ordinance.